

■ By Farzand Ahmed

What Mayawati wants, Mayawati gets and what better day to get what you want than your birthday? The rescheduled Makar Sankranti on January 15 that coincided with her 52nd birth anniversary provided the Uttar Pradesh chief minister with the perfect platform to unveil her dream project, the Ganga Expressway. To make sure that there were no speed-breakers, Samajwadi Party (SP) leaders, including her bete noire and party chief Mulayam Singh Yadav, his MP-son Akhilesh Yadav and brother and the party's working president Shivpal Yadav, were put under virtual house arrest while the police swarmed all the sensitive areas of state capital Lucknow.

The chief minister, in keeping with her agenda of pushing the state into the economic mainstream, had reason to be ruthless—SP and BJP along with V.P. Singh's Jan Morcha had planned a statewide protest against the launch of the Rs 40,000-crore project claiming it



ON THE FAST TRACK

Amid opposition, Mayawati launches the Rs 40,000-crore Ganga Expressway project to put the state's economy on a high growth trajectory

would lead to forcible acquisition of agricultural land and ruin the farmers. Shivpal as well as state BJP chief Ramapati Ram Tripathi had avowed to continue the agitation till the project was withdrawn. SP had mobilised over a lakh of its workers to foil the ground-breaking ceremony in Ballia. While SP had warned that the Nandigram agitation would be nothing in comparison once the farmers took to the streets, BJP had given it a religious twist by calling it 'Ram and Ganga bachao andolan'. Their activists held demonstrations in all the 19 districts through which the Expressway would pass. "The project will not only affect ecology, sociology and economy of the state but would

hurt the religious sentiment of people living along the Ganga," said state BJP spokesperson Hriday Narain Dixit. Faced with stiff opposition, Mayawati instead decided to unveil the project from inside her high-security Kalidas Marg official residence in Lucknow. Yet the ceremony was marked by a tragedy in the faraway national Capital. An SP worker from the state's Sultanpur district, Ranvijay Yadav, immolated himself at Delhi's Jantar Mantar and suffered 90 per cent burns while protesting against "death of democracy" in the Mayawati raj.

The 1,000-km road project has been billed as India's biggest infrastructure initiative so far by any state



UGLY TURN: Mayawati launches the project (top); immolation bid in Delhi government, trumpeted since September last year as 'Uttar Pradesh's Network of Prosperity'. As expected, the project has been awarded to Mayawati's favourite Jaya Prakash Associates (JPAL) which had submitted the lowest bid at Rs 29,355 crore. Though an official announcement is still awaited, it is the same JPAL which is executing the 186-km Taj Expressway to connect Agra with Noida. Mayawati had envisaged this Rs 15,000-crore